

Corrected Document

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Pilot project in Lahore Canal
to assess performance before
expansion across Punjab

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LAHORE: In a major step towards tackling plastic pollution, the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) of Punjab has launched its first skimmer boat or trash skimmer, designed to remove plastic waste from canals and rivers.

The boat will begin operations as a pilot project in the Lahore Canal, marking the introduction of a technology-based solution to address water pollution in the province.

The announcement was made during a seminar held here on Friday to mark the International Plastic Bag Free Day. Parliamentary Secretary for Environment Kansas Lianas attended the event as the chief guest while EPA Punjab Director General Dr Imran Hamid Sheikh was the guest of honor.

The EPA officials said the skimming boat installed with waste collection bin on its front would play a vital role in collecting floating plastic waste from waterways and supporting the province's broader campaign against plastic pollution. They said the pilot project in Lahore Canal would help assess the effectiveness of the technology before its potential expansion to other canals and rivers across Punjab.

The seminar brought together government officials, environmental experts, representatives of industry, civil society organizations, media personnel and other stakeholders. Participants renewed their commitment to avoid use of banned plastic bags and supporting efforts to make Punjab environmentally sustainable.

Highlighting the achievements of the anti-plastic campaign, the officials said more than 50,000 business owners had pledged not to use banned plastic bags. They added that enforcement teams had confiscated

over 600,000kg of prohibited plastic during the campaign and imposed fines exceeding Rs20m on violators.

Dr Imran Hamid Sheikh stressed that practical measures were essential to eliminate plastic pollution, saying that the real challenge would begin after the pledges as commitments needed to be translated into concrete action. He reaffirmed the EPA's determination to eliminate banned single-use plastic bags from

Punjab, saying that the enforcement teams would continue their operations against violators across the province.

The DG EPA said the anti-single-use plastic campaign would be further strengthened through technology-driven and data-based monitoring systems to improve enforcement and ensure compliance. He urged citizens to refrain from using banned plastic bags and support environmental protection initiatives.

He noted that implementation of the Punjab Plastic Management Strategy 2023 was continuing, with the registration of producers, sellers, waste collectors and recyclers underway to establish a more effective plastic waste management system.

Kansas Lianas said field enforcement was a difficult but essential national responsibility. She made it clear that environmental violations would not be tolerated under any pressure or recommendation and expressed pride in the EPA's field teams for their efforts in enforcing environmental laws. She also called on citizens, industries, non-governmental organizations, media organizations and civil society groups to work together with EPA Punjab in achieving the goal of making Punjab a plastic-free zone.

The seminar concluded with a collective pledge by participants that a plastic-free Punjab is a shared responsibility and requires the active participation of all segments of society. The launch of the skimming boat was widely viewed as a significant milestone in the province's ongoing efforts to curb plastic pollution and protect its waterways and environment.

EPA launches first skimmer boat to keep canals, rivers clean

Dawn